Abdulcader Maruhom Ayo

Dr. Abdulcader Maruhom Ayo (born c. 1963) is a Filipino academic leader, legal scholar, and engineer who currently serves as the **Executive Vice President (EVP) of the Mindanao State University (MSU) System**, one of the Philippines' foremost institutions for higher learning in Muslim Mindanao.

A Maranao polymath in the truest sense, Dr. Ayo built his career across continents and disciplines, starting as a mining and safety engineer in Manila and the oil fields of Saudi Arabia before returning home to become one of the MSU System's most trusted administrators.

He is perhaps best known as a topnotcher of the Special Shariah Bar Examinations and as the longtime Dean of the King Faisal Center for Islamic, Arabic and Asian Studies (KFCIAAS), where his seven-year leadership was recognized for its depth and consistency.

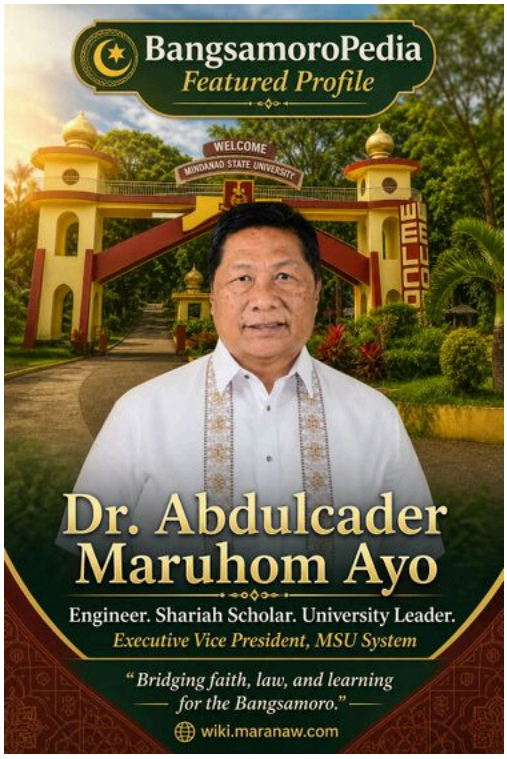
His guiding legacy: **bridging faith, law, and learning in service of the Bangsamoro people.**

Affectionately called "Dodong" or "Duds" by colleagues and friends, he represents a model of Muslim Filipino excellence rooted in both religious devotion and rigorous scholarship.

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Dr. Abdulcader Maruhom Ayo



Born	c. 1963
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Occupation	Academic administrator, legal scholar, engineer
Current position	Executive Vice President, MSU System
Employer	Mindanao State University System
Education	Ph.D. Philippine Studies; Juris Doctor; M.A. Islamic Studies; B.S. Mining Engineering
Credentials	Shariah Licentiate (Sh.L.); Civil Service Professional; Shariah Bar Topnotcher

Early Life and Background

Dr. Ayo was born around 1963, and while the source materials do not detail his precise birthplace, his life and career have been deeply intertwined with the Bangsamoro region and the broader Muslim Filipino community.

He grew up in a tradition that valued both faith and learning, a foundation that would later define how he approached every professional role he took on, whether as an engineer in the Middle East or as a dean shaping the next generation of Bangsamoro scholars.

His personal values, particularly his belief that "Family is Everything," have been a constant thread throughout a career that took him far from home before bringing him back to serve the communities that shaped him.

Education

Dr. Ayo's academic credentials are wide-ranging and reflect a man who refused to be confined to a single discipline.

His technical education began with a degree in **Mining Engineering**, which gave him the scientific grounding for his early career in the extractive industries.

He later earned a **Master of Arts in Islamic Studies**, deepening his understanding of the religious and legal traditions central to Bangsamoro identity.

He went on to earn a **Juris Doctor (JD)**, and passed the Special Shariah Bar Examinations in Manila, where he ranked among the **topnotchers**, a distinction that reflects both his legal acumen and his mastery of Islamic jurisprudence.

He also holds a **Shariah Licentiate (Sh.L.)** and is a **Civil Service Professional**, underscoring the breadth of his qualifications across religious, civil, and legal frameworks.

His academic journey culminated in a **Doctor of Philosophy in Philippine Studies**, a degree that brought together his experiences in law, culture, governance, and the particular challenges facing Muslim Filipinos in a pluralist society.

Professional Career

Engineering and International Service

Dr. Ayo's working life started in the technical sector.

In 1984, he served as a **Safety Engineer** at the Bureau of Mines Central Office in Manila, applying his mining engineering background to regulatory and workplace safety work at the national level.

From 1986 to 1997, he spent over a decade working as a **Senior Engineer** for a petroleum company in **Saudi Arabia**, gaining substantial international experience in one of the world's most demanding industrial environments.

This period abroad was not just a professional chapter; it also deepened his connection to the broader Islamic world, an experience that would later enrich his scholarship and his approach to Islamic education at MSU.

Return to Academia

After his stint overseas, Dr. Ayo transitioned into academic life, bringing both his technical background and his deepening legal and religious scholarship into the classroom.

He began teaching at the **College of Engineering at Adamson University** in Manila, one of the Philippines' well-regarded institutions, where he honed his skills as an educator.

Upon returning to Mindanao, he became a lecturer at the **MSU College of Law**, where he taught courses intersecting Islamic jurisprudence and the Philippine legal system.

He subsequently joined the **King Faisal Center for Islamic, Arabic and Asian Studies (KFCIAAS)**, which would become the central theater for the most consequential chapter of his career.

Administrative Leadership at KFCIAAS

Dr. Ayo's leadership at KFCIAAS unfolded over **two terms**, totaling a seven-year tenure as its **Dean**, a period that colleagues and the university administration have described as one of "exemplary leadership."

During his time as dean, he worked to strengthen KFCIAAS as an academic home for Islamic scholarship within the MSU System, supporting research, faculty development, and programs that serve both Muslim Filipino students and the wider Bangsamoro community.

His sustained leadership of the center stands as one of the defining contributions of his career, cementing his reputation as a steady, principled steward of one of the university's most culturally significant units.

Institutional Contributions

Appointment as Executive Vice President

In **August 2025**, MSU System President Atty. Paisalin P. Tago appointed Dr. Ayo as the **Executive Vice President of the MSU System**, formalized through **Special Order No. 1142-OP**.

The EVP role places him at the operational center of one of the Philippines' most important regional universities, responsible for translating the university's vision into day-to-day institutional action.

In this capacity, Dr. Ayo is a key figure in implementing the university's **9-Point Agenda**, a strategic framework aimed at strengthening MSU's academic programs, research output, community engagement, and institutional governance.

He has also been a consistent advocate for building an inclusive university environment, one that reflects the cultural and religious diversity of the Bangsamoro region while upholding standards of academic excellence.

Service to the Supreme Court of the Philippines

Beyond the campus, Dr. Ayo has served as a **Special Shariah Bar Examiner** for the **Supreme Court of the Philippines**, specifically handling the area of **Islamic Law on Inheritance**.

This role places him among a small circle of Filipino legal scholars trusted by the country's highest court to evaluate competence in Shariah law, a significant distinction that underscores his standing both within MSU and in the broader Philippine legal community.

Academic Achievements and Research

Dr. Ayo's scholarly work sits at the crossroads of Islamic law, Philippine governance, and education, areas that are especially critical to the ongoing development of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

His research on **Islamic Inheritance Law** examines the perceptions of ulama and professionals regarding the law as codified under **Presidential Decree 1083** (the Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines), contributing to ongoing conversations about how Shariah-based legal frameworks operate within the Philippine constitutional system.

He has also written on the role of **Information and Communications Technology (ICT)** in teacher education programs within the BARMM, addressing the practical challenges of modernizing education delivery in a region still navigating decades of conflict and underdevelopment.

His teaching expertise covers **Islamic Jurisprudence**, **Persons and Family Relations**, and **Islamic Court Procedure**, areas that are foundational to both the legal practice and the cultural fabric of Muslim Filipino communities.

Personal Values and Cultural Significance

Dr. Ayo is the kind of person who leads as much by character as by title.

Known to friends and colleagues as "Dodong" or "Duds," he carries a warmth and accessibility that belies the weight of his credentials, a quality that has made him a trusted figure not just within MSU but across the Bangsamoro scholarly community.

He credits much of his success to his faith and to his family. His wife, **Hadja Jannah Dayamala Macadindang Disamburun-Ayo**, and their two children are, by his own account, the anchor of everything he does.

His oft-repeated philosophy, "Family is Everything," reflects a deeply held conviction that personal integrity and strong family bonds are inseparable from meaningful public service.

Within the Bangsamoro region, he's frequently cited as a living example of what it means to be an "ideal Muslim" in public life: someone who takes faith seriously, pursues knowledge rigorously, and puts that knowledge in service of the community.

Legacy

Dr. Ayo's career tells a story that's still being written, but its contours are already clear.

He's a man who crossed disciplines and continents, from the mining offices of Manila to the oil fields of Saudi Arabia to the lecture halls of MSU, and brought everything he gathered back to serve the Bangsamoro people.

As a Shariah Bar topnotcher, a long-serving dean, a Supreme Court examiner, and now the Executive Vice President of the MSU System, he stands as a pillar of institutional continuity in a region where continuity is both rare and vital.

His legacy is rooted in the idea that Islamic scholarship and secular academic excellence don't have to be in tension. At their best, they strengthen each other, and Dr. Ayo has spent his career proving that.

Recognition

- Topnotcher, Special Shariah Bar Examinations, Manila
- Cited for "exemplary leadership" during his tenure as Dean of KFCIAAS, MSU
- Appointed Executive Vice President of the MSU System, August 2025 (Special Order No. 1142-OP)
- Commissioned as Special Shariah Bar Examiner, Supreme Court of the Philippines (Islamic Law on Inheritance)
- Recognized as a role model for the Bangsamoro academic community

Challenges

Dr. Ayo's work has not taken place in an easy environment.

The Bangsamoro region has long grappled with the legacy of armed conflict, political instability, and systemic underdevelopment, realities that shape the context in which MSU operates and that make the university's mission both more urgent and more difficult.

Leading within that context requires more than academic competence; it demands resilience, cultural fluency, and a willingness to navigate institutional complexity without losing sight of the communities the university is meant to serve.

His career trajectory, from technical worker to legal scholar to senior university administrator, reflects both the opportunities that hard work and faith can open and the persistence required to pursue them in a region where such paths are rarely smooth.

References

- Profile document: Dr. Abdulcader Maruhom Ayo, BangsamoroPedia Source File, 2025.
- Mindanao State University System, Special Order No. 1142-OP, August 2025.
- Presidential Decree No. 1083, Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines.

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